



This early 16th-century fresco of the Battle of Milvian Bridge is in the Apostolic Palace in the Vatican. Before the battle, the emperor Constantine is said to have seen a Christian monogram in a dream predicting his victory.

SINCE PERSECUTIONS IN THE 250S AND 260S, THE CHRISTIAN COMMUNITY

had experienced some 40 years of tranquillity in the Roman Empire. All this changed in 303 when Diocletian issued an **edict** ordering the **destruction of churches** and the handing over and **burning of Christian books**. A sterner edict followed, calling for the arrest of Christian clergy, and one in 304 ordered that all Christians offer a sacrifice to the pagan gods. Devout Christians could not accede to these demands, and many of them were martyred.

In 304, Diocletian fell seriously ill, and in 305 he announced that he and Maximian would abdicate.

Constantius Chlorus and **Galerius** would take over as Augusti, while the new Caesars were to be **Maximinus** (Galerius's nephew) and **Flavius Severus**

75,000
MAXENTIUS

50,000
CONSTANTINE

Battle numbers at Milvian Bridge
Maxentius's forces outnumbered those of Constantine, but his army became trapped between Constantine's men and the river.

(Galerius's army colleague). The new tetrarchy soon unraveled. **Constantius died** in Eboracum (modern York, England) in July 306 and the troops there proclaimed his son **Constantine** the new Augustus. By October, **Maxentius** (r. 306–12), the son of Maximian, was crowned emperor in Rome. Severus was killed trying to retake Rome from Maxentius, and Maximian restored himself to the position of Augustus. In 308, the **Conference of Carnuntum** was called to settle the disputes, presided over by Diocletian, who came out of retirement. Constantine accepted a demotion to Caesar in the West, with **Licinius** as Augustus (r. 308–24), while **Maximin Daia** became Galerius's Caesar in the East (r. 310–13). This new arrangement was no more successful than the old one.

In 311, **Galerius died** and **Maximin became Augustus** in the East. He ordered **renewed measures against Christians**. Constantine, meanwhile, invaded Italy and in October 312 defeated and killed Maxentius at the **Battle of Milvian Bridge**. Before the battle, Constantine is said to have dreamed of the **Chi-Rho symbol** and ordered his troops to mark it on their shields.

Licinius and Constantine met at Mediolanum (modern Milan) in 313, where they agreed to share power and issued the **Edict of Milan**, which granted toleration to all forms of worship, in effect **legalizing Christianity**. Licinius then turned East and defeated Maximin Daia, securing control

over the Eastern provinces. The alliance between Constantine and Licinius broke down in 316; they patched up a peace in 317, and for six years the Roman Empire relapsed into an uneasy calm.

In China, Wudi's successor **Huidi** (r. 290–306) was mentally disabled and so a succession of regents contended for imperial control. Huidi's brother **Huaidi** (r. 307–12) invited the northern **Xiongnu tribesmen** to help him against the competing Chinese factions, but they took him prisoner. The **last Western Jin emperor Mindi** (r. 313–16) saw the Xiongnu sack the capital of Chang'an (modern Xi'an); the Jin moved south, where **Yuandi** (r. 317–23) became the **first Eastern Jin emperor** in 317.



Chi-Rho symbol
The monogram of Chi-Rho, the first two letters of Christ's name in Greek, became an important early symbol of Christianity.



Palace of Diocletian
Diocletian built the great palace at Split, Croatia, for his retirement after his abdication in 305. Here, he tended his cabbages.



Early spread of Christianity

Christianity spread in the 2nd and 3rd centuries until there were strong Christian communities in Anatolia, southern Gaul, Italy, Egypt, and the province of Africa (Tunisia).

KEY

■ Areas strongly Christian by 325

